THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR

IN THE SECOND HALF of the 5th century BCE Sparta, Corinth, and other city-states of the Peloponnese fought to throw off the dominance of Athens. While the Spartans were superior on land, the Athenians' superior seamanship generally gave them the upper hand in battles fought at sea. It was only after the disastrous failure of the Athenian expedition to Syracuse in Sicily (415–413 BCE) that the Peloponnesians were able to make a serious bid for naval superiority. When their fleet was destroyed at Aegospotami in 405, the Athenians had lost the war.

THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR 431—404 BCE

In response to the threat of Persia, many Greek city-states on the islands and coastline of the Aegean formed themselves into the Delian League. The dominant member was Athens, whose wealth and naval power transformed the league into an Athenian empire, incurring the enmity of Sparta, Corinth, and other cities outside the league.

KEY

- Athenian Empire and allies of Athens c.431 BCE
- Sparta and allied states
- Athenian expedition to Sicily 415 BCE
- Athenian victory
- Spartan victory
- Inconclusive battle



CORINTHIAN WAR WITH CORCYRA

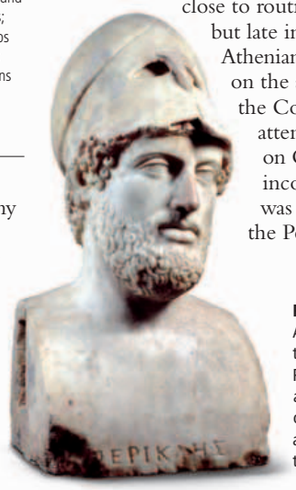
SYBOTA



Date 433 BCE
Forces Corcyraeans and Athenians: 140 ships; Corinthians: 150 ships
Losses Corcyraeans: c.70 ships; Corinthians c. 30 ships

Location Between Corfu and Sybota

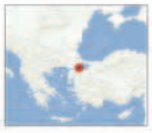
In 433 BCE Corinth assembled a fleet to subdue its restive colony Corcyra (Corfu). Following a similar conflict two years earlier the Corcyraeans had agreed a treaty with Pericles, the Athenian leader, and now appealed to Athens for help. At first the Athenians sent only 10 triremes to give moral support. According to Thucydides, the Corinthians and Corcyraeans fought "in the old-fashioned way," using their ships for boarding with soldiers rather than for a ramming contest. The Corinthians came close to routing their enemy, but late in the day 20 more Athenian triremes arrived on the scene, deterring the Corinthians from attempting a landing on Corcyra itself. The inconclusive battle was the prelude to the Peloponnesian War.



Pericles
Athenian leader during the city's "golden age," Pericles, was unable to avert the deterioration of relations with Sparta and Corinth that led to the Peloponnesian War.

PELOPONNESIAN WAR

CYZICUS



Date 410 BCE
Forces Athenians 80–100 ships; Spartans 60–80 ships
Losses Athenians: few; Spartans 60–80 ships

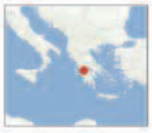
Location
The Hellespont

The Athenians, with Alcibiades as their principal commander, launched an amphibious operation to recapture the city of Cyzicus from the Spartans. Despite an unfortunate tendency to defect to the other side, Alcibiades was one of Athens's most talented military leaders. He had just been reinstated as a general after a political coup in 411 BCE. Sailing from a forward base on the island of Proconnesus, Alcibiades first landed a body of soldiers south of Cyzicus. He then led a squadron of 40 triremes toward the city, while two other squadrons under generals Thrasybulus and Theramenes followed some distance behind, keeping close to shore. When they sighted Alcibiades with such a weak force, the Spartans sensed an easy victory. The Spartan general Mindarus led his triremes out of Cyzicus harbor. As Alcibiades appeared to flee, they pursued.

The Athenian trap now closed. Thrasybulus and Theramenes appeared inshore of the Spartans, cutting them off from the harbor, and Alcibiades turned to attack. Many Spartan ships were sunk; the remainder succeeded in reaching a beach. A fierce land battle ensued, which the Athenians won.

PELOPONNESIAN WAR

NAUPACTUS



Date 429 BCE
Forces Athenians: 20 ships Peloponnesians: 77 ships
Losses Athenians: 1 ship; Peloponnesians: 6 ships

Location Off Naupactus, Gulf of Corinth

In the winter of 430, a small squadron of Athenian triremes under Phormio established a base at Naupactus on the Corinthian Gulf. The following summer the Peloponnesian League sent a convoy of 47 ships carrying troops through the gulf. Phormio ambushed the convoy, which was forced into a defensive circle, then attacked and routed.

The Peloponnesians swiftly sought revenge, dispatching a fleet of 77 ships with the bold Spartan general Brasidas among its commanders. Phormio had received no reinforcements, so the Athenians were outnumbered by almost four to one. The two fleets moored opposite one another at the mouth of the gulf. Faster and more skillful at maneuver, the Athenians wanted to fight in open waters; Brasidas was determined to force them to fight in a confined space, where maneuver would be impossible.

The Peloponnesians headed into the gulf, moving in column toward Naupactus. Obliged to defend his base, Phormio shadowed them on a parallel course close to the land. Choosing their moment, the Peloponnesians turned and bore down on the Athenian line. Nine of the Athenian triremes—the rear of the force—were trapped and forced to the shore, where fierce hand-to-hand fighting took place. The others fled for Naupactus pursued by some 20 enemy ships. As they reached the base, the rearmost trireme turned in a tight circle around a merchant vessel anchored offshore and rammed its nearest pursuer. Thrown into confusion, the Peloponnesians lost formation. An Athenian counterattack scattered them and put them to flight.

WITNESS TO WAR

THUCYDIDES

GREEK HISTORIAN

ACTION BEFORE THE BATTLE OF NAUPACTUS

"… the enemy's ships were now in a narrow space, and what with the wind and the small craft dashing against them, at once fell into confusion: ***ship fell foul of ship****, while the crews were pushing them off with poles, and by their* ***shouting, swearing, and struggling*** *with one another, made captains' orders and boatswains' cries alike inaudible, and through being unable for want of practice to clear their oars in the rough water,* ***prevented the vessels from obeying their helmsmen*** *properly. At this moment Phormio gave the signal, and the Athenians attacked."*